When forms of discrimination intersect

Bringing an intersectional perspective to AntiFake

Discriminatory narratives do not always target people on the basis of a single characteristic.

Racism, sexism, LGTBI-phobia, Islamophobia, antigypsyism, ableism, immigration status and economic inequality can appear in the same narrative and reinforce one another.

Intersectionality helps us see these intersections.

It is a way of understanding that inequalities and discrimination relate to different dimensions of people's lives. When several of those dimensions intersect, they can produce specific and more

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intense forms of discrimination, exclusion or vulnerability.

This perspective also matters when we analyse disinformation.

When a false rumour activates more than one prejudice

False rumours and discriminatory narratives can be constructed using different prejudices at the same time.

A message can single out a person's origin and, at the same time, their religion.

It can use racist and sexist prejudices.

It can associate immigration status with poverty or criminality.

It can attack a person because of their sexual orientation while also using stereotypes linked to their origin.

When a false rumour activates more than one prejudice

These elements do not necessarily appear separately. They can form part of the same narrative and reinforce one another.

Bringing an intersectional perspective to AntiFake therefore means learning to identify which forms of discrimination are present in a message, how they intersect and what this intersection does to the representation of a person or group.

Words and images also construct these forms of discrimination

Intersectionality does not only help us observe who information discusses.

It also helps us examine how they are discussed.

Which characteristics are highlighted.

Which labels are used.

Which images are chosen.

Which behaviours are attributed to particular groups.

Whose voices appear as authoritative in explaining a

Words and images also construct these forms of discrimination

situation, and which people appear only as the subjects of a news story.

When different prejudices coincide in these representations, a narrative can reinforce more than one form of discrimination at the same time.

Recognising this helps us understand not only whether information is true or false, but also what view of people it is helping to construct.

One more layer for the AntiFake checklist

The intersectional perspective

When we identify potentially discriminatory elements in a message, we can add these questions to the AntiFake checklist:

☐ Which characteristics are being used to single out this person or group?

☐ Is more than one form of discrimination present in the same narrative?

☐ How do these forms of discrimination intersect and reinforce one another?

☐ What stereotypes are being associated with these characteristics?

The intersectional perspective

☐ Would the narrative affect or represent everyone in this group in the same way?

☐ Whose voices are telling the story, and which affected people are left out?

Looking from an intersectional perspective means broadening the question: not only who is being targeted, but why, through which forms of discrimination, and what happens when these forms of discrimination intersect.